PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Toyota Land Cruiser Prado 120

2002–2009 · J120 · GRJ120 · KDJ120

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **1KD-FTV: injector seats and oil pickup**
  Ask for injector-seat (washer) receipts. Listen for a rattle and look for white smoke on a cold start, then shine a light through the sump drain-plug hole. CarsGuide and Unsealed 4X4 both say carbon on the pickup screen means a suspect engine. Trucks built from August 2007 got aluminum seats.
- [ ] **1KD-FTV: injector age**
  AustralianCar.Reviews says the injectors typically fail at 120,000–140,000 km. Signs are a loud knock when cold, rough idle, poor running under load and worse fuel economy. Both it and 4X4 Australia suggest testing them at every service and replacing them at about 100,000 km, so ask whether they've been done.
- [ ] **Timing belt or chain?**
  The 1GR-FE V6 and the 2.7 fours use chains. The 1KD-FTV, 1KZ-TE and 5VZ-FE use belts, and HD Automotive quotes Toyota's 1KD interval as 150,000 km or five years. No receipt means budget for the belt and water pump.
- [ ] **Cracked dash and split rear door**
  CarsGuide reports dashboards cracking near the passenger airbag on early 120s, and rear-door skins splitting along the hinge side under the weight of the spare. Check both, and look closely at the door if a heavier spare tire has been fitted.
- [ ] **Rear air suspension (Grande and top grades)**
  If it has air springs, check that it levels and holds height overnight. 4X4 Australia warns that self-leveling rear air makes aftermarket suspension 'a much bigger (and more expensive) task' than on coil-sprung trucks.
- [ ] **V6 transmission**
  4X4 Australia suggests skipping the early four-speed automatic V6 in favor of the five-speed auto (late 2005 on) or the rarer six-speed manual.
- [ ] **Test the center diff lock**
  Engage the center lock off pavement and make sure the light comes on and goes off. IH8MUD's GX 470 pre-buy advice applies to the Prado's shared system: a seized actuator is an expensive surprise on a truck that's never left the road.
- [ ] **Import eligibility**
  A J120 can't be imported into the US until it's 25 years old by date of manufacture. The first ones qualify from September 2027. A '2003 Prado' advertised as US-legal today should set off alarms.

YEARS TO KNOW

April 2003	RECALL	Australian recall PRA 2003/6123 for the fuel pulsation damper on early GRJ120s
Late 2005	SWEET SPOT	Five-speed automatic arrives for the V6. 4X4 Australia says to skip the earlier four-speed V6 autos and buy a five-speed (or the rare six-speed manual)

Late 2006	BEWARE	Euro IV 1KD-FTV (127 kW, 410 Nm) with 5AT and 6MT; Australia's diesel switches from the 1KZ-TE. Until August 2007 the 1KD has copper injector seats, which can fail and let blow-by gases carbon up the oil pick-up, so ask whether they have been replaced
Aug 2007	SWEET SPOT	Aluminium injector seats replace the failure-prone copper ones on the 1KD-FTV; equipment and safety upgrades. 4X4 Australia rates the 2006–08 trucks as the high point of the 120

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Fuel pulsation damper assembly (Australia)**
  GRJ120 built 29 October 2002 – 22 March 2003 · PRA 2003/6123

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Model code = engine + body**
  GRJ = 1GR-FE 4.0 V6, KDJ = 1KD-FTV diesel, KZJ = 1KZ-TE diesel, VZJ = 5VZ-FE 3.4 V6, RZJ = 3RZ-FE and TRJ = 2TR-FE 2.7 fours. Toyota's own list shows 120/121 as five-door codes and 125 as the three-door.
- ☐ **Copper or aluminum injector seats**
  On a 1KD-FTV, trucks built from August 2007 have aluminum injector seats; earlier trucks have copper ones. Ask for receipts if the copper seats have been replaced.
- ☐ **Air or coils at the rear**
  Electronically controlled rear air suspension came on the Australian Grande and top Japanese grades (TZ G Selection). Look for the air springs and compressor before you price a lift.
- ☐ **Rear diff**
  ExplorOz owners say Australian GX/GXL trucks have a rear LSD, while VX and Grande have an open rear diff with traction control. Some markets list a rear diff lock, so check for the switch and confirm it works.
- ☐ **Prado or rebadged GX?**
  IH8MUD has threads on rebadging GX 470s as Prados. A 2UZ-FE V8 and a US VIN mean it's a Lexus GX 470, whatever the tailgate says.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/land-cruiser/prado-120/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks